

iMac, Refreshed

Apple has always been a trendsetter in the domain of industrial design and it has outdone itself once again with the new iMac. Sporting one of the most innovative computer designs in recent years, the flat 15-inch TFT screen beams a crystal clear display even when viewed from almost edge-on angles. This screen rests on a chrome-plated steel rod that facilitates easy positioning of the screen either horizontally or vertically. The small but powerful Apple Pro speakers look similar to glass snooker balls and deliver a surprising amount of acoustic punch. However, the high point of the design lies in the semi-spherical base, which houses all the system components.

The iMac is powered by a 700 MHz Power PC G4 processor with 256 KB of L2 cache running at full speed, 256 MB of SDRAM that can be upgraded to 1 GB, a 40 GB hard disk, a 12x8x32x CD-Writer and an nVidia GeForce 2 MX graphics card. There is virtually every type of connectivity option on the periphery of the base unit, including FireWire, USB, speaker and headphone jacks, modem and Ethernet ports and an extra VGA output to connect an additional monitor for dual display. Adding to the 'solid ice' looks of the systems is the

operating system itself—it came loaded with Mac OS X, which with its aqua interface, gelled very well with the squeaky clean appearance of the machine. The OS incorporated iTunes for managing music files, which also enables it to be coupled with Apple's new iPod MP3 player. With the brilliant TFT display, QuickTime files looked truly astounding and this, when coupled with the speakers' sound quality, makes watching movies a great experience. The system also included Microsoft Office X along with other goodies such as Roxio Toast 5, Titanium iMovie and VCD creator, which makes it fun and easy to share your experiences with family and friends. Due to its aesthetic appeal and flaunt value, this machine will easily find a place on the desk of top executives and aficionados.

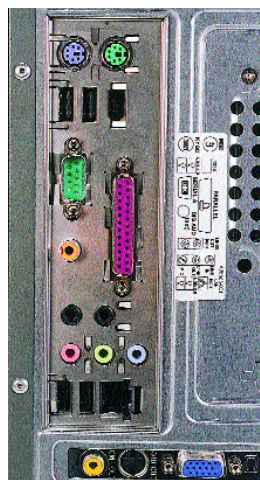
Price: Rs 1,20,700; **Contact:** Apple Computers Intl Pvt Ltd; **E-mail:** indiainfo@asia.apple.com; **Phone:** 080-555057



controller. This storage subsystem configuration resulted in impressive data transfer rates in the performance benchmarks. It also featured a 17-inch monitor and a 16x Pioneer DVD drive that had a slot-in interface. The motherboard had a four-channel integrated sound chip, but the bundled speaker system was a stereo set with a subwoofer—the only thing that stopped it from being suitable as a home theatre system. With four USB 2.0 ports and one FireWire port, there are enough resources for connecting a host of external peripheral devices.

The Zenith Premium Corporate PC also featured a decent set of specifications and came bundled in a small form factor tailored for the corporate world. It featured a 2.4 GHz Pentium 4 processor on an 845G-based motherboard with 128 MB of DDR RAM and a conventional 40 GB, 5,400-rpm Seagate hard disk. It also housed two USB 2.0 compliant ports on its front panel.

The Visualan Celebrity and the Vintron Elixir 1000 appeared on the lower end of the specifications spectrum—both these systems were based upon a 1.2 GHz Celeron (with the Tualatin core) and ran on a dated Intel 810E-based motherboard. These systems used graphics and sound that were integrated into the motherboard and featured 128 MB of SDRAM and standard 15-inch monitors. Their specifications were virtually identical, but the Vintron Elixir 1000 had a 56K PCI modem.



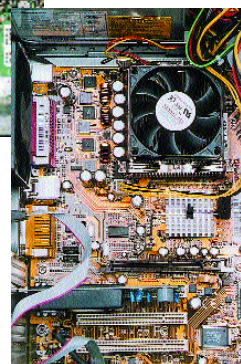
The HCL Beanstalk 4455 has nearly every port—including FireWire!

Upgradability options: The Visualan Wisdom and the Visualan Lavish featured large and airy cabinets with ample room for expansion. Their motherboards had six PCI slots each, out of which only one was used for a PCI modem. In comparison, the HCL Beanstalk 4455 and the Compaq Presario 3705AP featured only four and two slots respectively.

Since most computers were based on the 845 family of chipsets, they were able to support the Socket 478 Pentium and the new Celeron processors up to 2.6 GHz speeds. However, the two systems that were based upon the 810E chipsets had an upgradability handicap—the Visualan Celebrity and the Vintron



The Visualan Wisdom (above) offers plenty of room for adding expansion cards, unlike the Compaq Presario 3705AP (right)



Elixir 1000 were based upon the older Socket 370 interface and the highest they could go was to P-III Tualatin processors—they cannot be upgraded to a Pentium 4.

Some of the Pentium 4 systems here were based upon SDRAM memory, which proved to be the biggest bottleneck in the systems. These included the Vintron Elixir 1000 and 4000, the QMAX Quadrant and the Visualan Celebrity and the Visualan Wisdom. These systems cannot be upgraded to newer and faster forms of memory such as DDR RAM or RDRAM. While SDRAM is suited to non-demanding applications, it can quickly turn into a bottleneck during more strenuous tasks. However, the Visualan Wisdom, like the Qmax Quadrant and the Vintron Elixir 4000, had three RAM slots allowing for a greater amount of RAM to be installed as compared to the other SDRAM based systems. All the DDR based systems had just two slots for RAM but since the density of DDR RAM is greater than that of SDRAM, these systems could accommodate up to 3 GB of system memory.

Build quality: We evaluated the build quality of the PCs by observing the overall construction of the systems and its details.